THE HIGH SCHOOL AI READINESS TOOLKIT

FOR ISD SUPERINTENDENTS & HIGH SCHOOL PRINCIPALS

Your students are already living in the AI economy. Your curriculum isn't.

A working guide for updating curriculum, classroom practice, and career preparation for the job market your graduates are walking into. Take what fits your school and leave the rest.

Demand for AI fluency in US job postings has grown sevenfold in two years, faster than any other skill in McKinsey's analysis. Students graduating this spring will see that demand in the postings they apply to.

MCKINSEY GLOBAL INSTITUTE · 2025

GOVERNANCE GUARDRAILS · NON-NEGOTIABLE

Faculty Authority

Curriculum changes go through existing teacher and faculty governance. The ACIL coordinates. Faculty approve.

Parent Consultation

Families are consulted before adoption, not informed after. Listening sessions happen before any required course launch.

Course Changes

Course dissolution and new requirements go through board approval. AI audits identify. They do not eliminate.

Teachers Are Never Replaced

AI is a subject of study and a professional support tool. Teachers stay responsible for instruction, assessment, and student relationships.

Built on ITDF 2025–2026 research · WEF Future of Jobs Report 2025 · McKinsey · PwC · Brookings · UNESCO Guidance for Generative AI in Education 2023 · Gallup / Walton Family Foundation / GSV Voices of Gen Z, April 2026

Version 4.1 · October 2026 · Ryan Lester · rlperspectives.com

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Sections are modular. Tier 1 (thirty days, one campus) uses Sections 02 and 06. Tiers 2 and 3 add the rest in the order they appear.

START HERE

A Menu, Not a Mandate

Nobody outside your building knows your school as well as your teachers do. Treat this toolkit as a menu. Take the parts that fit, change what doesn't, and ask your teachers what would help them first. Nothing here replaces your state rules, your district policy, or your professional judgment.

WHAT THIS TOOLKIT IS TRYING TO DO

1. **Cut the scramble.** Teachers are already fielding AI questions with no shared answer. One written plan takes that weight off individual teachers.
2. **Give you a real answer** when a parent or board member asks what you're doing about AI.
3. **Protect student data** before a tool is adopted, not after.

What it does not claim: it does not promise higher test scores, and nothing in it has been measured on scores. If scores are your first priority, track your own scores next to your pilot and trust that number over this document.

Tier 1: 30 days, one campus. A teacher survey, a course audit, and a written student AI use policy. No new courses, no new hires.

Tier 2: one semester. Add the named lead with protected time, the data privacy review, and teacher training for the departments that volunteer.

Tier 3: the full two-year cycle. Curriculum changes, the AI-Free Declaration Track, succession planning, and the annual accountability checklist.

WHERE THIS STANDS

This toolkit has not yet been piloted in a school. It was built with AI, checked against published research, and revised after review. The first schools to try any part of it will shape the next version. Lessons-learned feedback is welcome and will be credited only with permission. Details are on the project page at github.com/Lesterhau/ai-education-toolkits.

01

THE CASE FOR URGENCY

The Numbers Behind the Decision to Act

This section is short on purpose. It's the data you need to justify acting.

82%

of global technology experts say AI will play a significantly larger role in daily life and key societal systems in **10 years or less**.

ELON UNIVERSITY IMAGINING THE DIGITAL FUTURE CENTER · 2026 · N=386

7×

Job postings that require AI fluency rose nearly sevenfold in two years, faster than any other skill in McKinsey's analysis of US postings. Postings measure employer demand, not jobs filled.

MCKINSEY GLOBAL INSTITUTE · 2025

19%

Employment of workers aged 22 to 25 in the most AI-exposed jobs is 19% below where it would otherwise be. Experienced workers show no comparable gap, and the same study finds no economy-wide job displacement. This is early data from payroll records, and it points at the entry-level jobs your graduates will apply for.

BRYNJOLFSSON, CHANDAR & CHEN, STANFORD DIGITAL ECONOMY LAB (ADP PAYROLL DATA) · AUG 2026

56%

In PwC's analysis of job ads, roles that require AI skills pay a 56% premium, up from 25% the year before. That is a pay gap seen in ads, not proof that AI skills cause higher pay, and it may shrink as the skill spreads.

PWC GLOBAL AI JOBS BAROMETER 2025 · JOB-AD DATA FOR 2024

<10%

of schools and universities globally had developed formal policies or guidance on generative AI, surveyed **after** ChatGPT crossed 100 million users. The technology got there before the governance did.

UNESCO GLOBAL SURVEY · 2023 · N=450+

31%

of Gen Z now report feeling **anger** toward AI, up 9 points in one year. Excitement dropped from 36% to 22%. The generation expected to lead AI adoption is souring on it instead. This is what no curriculum looks like from the inside.

GALLUP / WALTON FAMILY FOUNDATION / GSV VENTURES · APRIL 2026

> The future of education is not about teaching students to use AI. It is about teaching them to remain the authors of their own thinking, even when AI is available to do the thinking for them.
>
> THE POSITION THIS TOOLKIT ARGUES FROM

Gen Z is pushing back, and paying a price for it

A Gallup survey released in April 2026 found that excitement about AI among 14- to 29-year-olds fell 14 percentage points in a single year, down to 22%. Anger toward the technology rose to 31%. Nearly half of employed Gen Zers surveyed, 48%, say the risks of AI in the workforce outweigh the benefits, up from 37% the year before.

A separate Numerator survey of more than 5,000 consumers found that 57% of Gen Z non-users say they aren't open to adopting AI, compared to 32% of Boomers. Older Americans are now more open to AI than the generation that grew up with smartphones. Nothing in the history of consumer technology adoption looks like that.

The concerns are real and documented. Reporting on teen AI refusers keeps surfacing the same themes: AI devalues art, makes people lazy, harms the environment, and produces something fundamentally inauthentic. A generation raised inside algorithmic inauthenticity, from social media feeds to manufactured influencer content, has turned on the next wave of it. That instinct deserves respect.

The problem is the price tag on the instinct. A student who declines to engage with AI on principle is opting out of the skill set that currently carries a 56% pay premium in job ads (PwC, 2025). The labor market doesn't offer a principled-objector exemption. The districts that serve these students best are the ones that take the concerns seriously: address the environmental cost, acknowledge the creativity questions, give the ethical objections a real platform, and then teach critical fluency anyway. The alternative is graduating students who carry a principled skepticism and an employability gap at the same time. Nobody wins that way.

The equity problem

AI disruption is not hitting students equally. 79% of employed women work in occupations highly exposed to generative AI automation, compared to 58% of men (Kenan Institute analysis of US workforce data). And among the 6.1 million US workers who combine high AI exposure with the lowest capacity to adapt if displacement hits, a group concentrated in clerical and administrative roles, 86% are women (Brookings, 2026). If your district serves students, especially young women, who are preparing for administrative, customer service, or entry-level professional roles, inaction on AI education is a choice to leave those students more exposed. The gender gap in AI exposure is a civil rights issue. AI is where it shows up most visibly.

UNESCO: THE TRAINING DATA PROBLEM LANDS HARDEST ON YOUR ELL STUDENTS

UNESCO's 2023 guidance identifies an equity risk most district AI policies ignore: the training data behind most publicly available GenAI tools reflects Global North, English-language norms. Communities with minimal digital presence, including many immigrant communities and lower-income communities of color, are underrepresented in the data. The outputs these tools produce reflect the values, idioms, cultural references, and rhetorical conventions of whoever dominated the internet when the training data was scraped.

For English Language Learner students, that creates a compounding disadvantage. The tool is less fluent in their linguistic and cultural context, may produce less useful output when prompts reflect non-English conventions, and may assess their writing through a lens that pathologizes non-dominant English forms. Your AI literacy curriculum should include explicit instruction on training data bias and whose perspective these tools were built to reflect. Students who understand this evaluate AI outputs more critically, and teachers who understand it grade more fairly when AI is in the classroom.

Cautionary case: the Bennett School, Houston, April 2026

In April 2026, ABC13 reported on the Bennett School, a Houston voucher school where students spend a two-hour academic block on AI-tailored software and the rest of the day in athletic training. The reaction was immediate: parents and educators looked at the model and saw screens where a school was supposed to be.

The Bennett School model may be an outlier. It still became the frame through which every AI-in-schools story that followed got read, including coverage of programs that keep certified teachers in the room. Without a documented framework that clearly distinguishes responsible AI integration from what the Bennett School did, no district can tell that story credibly. When the standard doesn't exist, skepticism fills the gap. This toolkit should exist before any program launches, so one school's failure doesn't contaminate everything after it.

WHAT WE DON'T KNOW (AND YOU SHOULD SAY THIS PART OUT LOUD)

We don't know with certainty which specific jobs will exist in 2035–2040. We don't know the optimal age to introduce specific AI concepts; the developmental research is genuinely early. We don't know which AI tools will still be dominant in 2030. What we do know is that the skills required, critical thinking, ethical reasoning, AI fluency, data literacy, adaptability, are durable no matter which tools survive. Build for those, not for ChatGPT specifically.

On the hype-cycle risk: if AI disruption proves slower than current projections, the curriculum choices in this toolkit remain sound. Verification, ethical reasoning, adaptability, and critical evaluation are valuable regardless of AI's trajectory. The 56% wage premium exists today because the skill is scarce, which is why districts that move first produce graduates who capture it. The goal is making sure no student reaches the labor market without skills that are fast becoming baseline.

What Ohio and Idaho actually did, and what's still missing

Ohio and Idaho both passed laws requiring districts to adopt AI policies by July 1, 2026, a deadline that has now passed. Here is what each state got right, and where the gaps remain.

Ohio (House Bill 96). The first state to legally require every public district to adopt an AI policy. Ohio's Department of Education and Workforce published a model policy that districts could adopt or customize, on a statutory clock: the model by December 31, 2025, district adoption by July 1, 2026. The model covers acceptable use, academic integrity, AI literacy in curriculum, FERPA-aligned limits on entering student PII into third-party tools, a process for vetting AI products, and a standing district AI workgroup that must include a special education representative, a requirement most state guidance skips entirely.

What Ohio's model left out: a named implementation role with a job description. A three-zone tiered policy with actual enforcement. An AI-Free Declaration Track for ethical objectors. A succession protocol. Specific vendor contract requirements beyond FERPA. The law requires a policy. It doesn't say what the policy must do. A district can adopt the model verbatim and be compliant. It won't, by itself, be ready.

Idaho (Senate Bill 1227, signed March 2026). Requires a statewide generative AI framework that must, by statute, ensure that no AI tool replaces or eliminates a human teacher. The framework serves as the foundation for local district and charter school policies, professional development, procurement practices, and statewide standards. Idaho's Department of Education published it in 2026, built by a statewide working group of educators, technology leaders, and cybersecurity experts. The grade-level standards that flow from it are still in development.

What Idaho left out: a named district-level implementation role with a job description and 30-day action plan. A three-zone AI use policy. An AI-Free Declaration Track. A succession protocol. Specific vendor contract language. Idaho's law is newer and broader than Ohio's, but the district-level specifics are still being developed.

> **This toolkit was built to fill what both state laws left out.** Ohio districts: adopt the state model for compliance, then build the implementation infrastructure here. Idaho districts: this gives you the district-level specifics now.

02 FIRST MOVE

Before You Do Anything Else: Name Your AI Curriculum Integration Lead

Every campus that pulls this off has one owner. Not a committee. Not a shared Google Doc with fourteen stakeholders. One person per campus. This is the first action item in this document, and everything else depends on it. Until you name this person, nothing else here will stick.

> **A note on scale:** in a single-campus or small district, "one owner" can mean one person reporting directly to the superintendent. In a district with dozens or hundreds of campuses, it means one ACIL per campus, each reporting to their own principal, not 100 people reporting to one superintendent. A District AI Coordinator role for aggregating progress across campuses is described later in this section.

Committees diffuse accountability. One named person with clear authority, adequate time, and direct access to their principal produces results. The committee produces the report about why results weren't produced.

Who is this person?

The AI Curriculum Integration Lead (ACIL) should be a current, trusted, full-time faculty or staff member. Not an outside consultant, not the IT director, not a committee chair. Here is what to look for, and what to avoid.

Look for these traits	Avoid these assignments
Respected by peers, not just by administration. Faculty follow people they trust. A top-down appointment of someone unpopular will fail on contact with the faculty lounge. This is non-negotiable.	**The IT director.** This is a curriculum and pedagogy job, not an infrastructure job. IT directors think about tools, not learning. Those are different skill sets and different cultures.
Already curious about technology. They don't need to be an expert. They need to be genuinely interested and willing to learn in public. Curiosity is trainable. Resistance isn't.	**An outside consultant.** When the contract ends, the institutional knowledge leaves with them. This role requires sustained relationships with faculty, students, and community partners.
Comfortable with ambiguity. AI education is moving faster than any curriculum committee. This person will make judgment calls without a playbook. They need to be okay with that.	**The most tech-enthusiastic teacher.** Enthusiasm is not effectiveness. Someone who lives in Discord and loves every new app may not have the pedagogical depth or the peer relationships to move an institution.
A teacher-first identity. They must stay connected to what happens in classrooms, not just in administrative planning. The best people for this role never stop thinking about how students experience learning.	**A committee of five people.** If five people share the job, no one owns it. When things get hard, everyone is waiting for someone else to push. One owner, with clear authority.

Look for these traits	Avoid these assignments
Willing to hold people accountable. This role means following up when faculty don't complete PD, when departments don't update course materials, when commitments slip. They need to be able to have direct conversations.	**Someone who's already overloaded.** Add this to a teacher already running three extracurriculars and carrying a full load, and you are setting them up to fail and the program up to die.

The role, posted internally

AI Curriculum Integration Lead (ACIL). Campus-level role · reports to campus principal · seated on the school improvement team · two-year appointment, renewable.

Post this internally. It should read like an opportunity, not a burden. The right person will want it. **Compensation:** 1–2 course release periods per semester plus a $2,000–$4,000 annual stipend, or one additional daily conference/planning period in place of or alongside the stipend, depending on your contract structure and budget. Note that real implementation cost, including substitute coverage, runs $12,000–$30,000+ annually per campus. Size the investment to match the mandate.

What they own	What they do not own
• Master task list for AI modernization implementation • Faculty PD calendar: all AI training sessions • Employer advisory council coordination • Student AI Ethics Advisory Board facilitation • Annual AI Readiness Report to the campus principal (the District AI Coordinator rolls this up for board reporting in multi-campus districts) • Curriculum audit tracking and follow-up • Resource library maintenance, updated quarterly • AI use policy maintenance and annual review	• Rewriting the district's adopted curriculum (faculty integrate AI into their own lesson plans within it) • Technical IT infrastructure or tool purchasing • Disciplinary action for policy violations (an admin function) • Every teacher's individual lesson plans • Budget authority beyond their stipend • Community communications (that's you) • HR decisions related to AI competency • Being the only person who knows anything about AI

The ACIL's first 30 days: exact action steps

Hand this list to your ACIL on day one.

Week 1: complete the AI landscape survey

Send a 10-question survey to every teacher: "Do you currently use AI tools? Which ones? Have you received AI-related PD in the last 12 months? What is your comfort level with AI tools on a 1–5 scale? What questions do you have about AI in your classroom?" This is your baseline. You cannot measure improvement without it.

Week 1: audit every course that currently touches AI, data, or technology

Create a simple spreadsheet: course name, teacher, grade, does it address AI (Y/N), what specifically it covers, estimated percentage of students who take it. This is your gap map.

Week 2: complete the free MIT/Google Generative AI for Educators course

Two hours, free, and it covers the basics every ACIL needs before facilitating faculty PD. The URL is grow.google/ai-for-educators. The course was developed by Google in collaboration with MIT RAISE. Take notes on what faculty will struggle with.

Week 2: contact AI4K12 and register for their educator community

AI4K12 (ai4k12.org) is a CSTA/AAAI-backed initiative with free curriculum materials, grade-band progression charts, and a practitioner community. This is your primary curricular framework resource. Register and download their Five Big Ideas in AI poster and guidelines.

Week 3: schedule one-on-one conversations with every department head

Not a group meeting. Individual conversations. Ask: "What does your department currently do about AI? What are your teachers' biggest concerns? What would make this easier for your team?" Listen more than you talk. These relationships are your implementation infrastructure.

Week 4: route the AI goal through your existing improvement-planning process, or present a standalone plan if you don't have one

Before inventing a new reporting ritual, check whether one already exists. Most states require some form of annual campus or school improvement plan. Texas mandates a Campus Improvement Plan (CIP) under state law for every campus regardless of Title I status. Other states use different names (School Improvement Plan, Continuous Improvement Plan, Local Improvement Plan) with different triggers, and some only require it for underperforming campuses. Where a body like a school improvement team already meets regularly and reviews progress against goals, add a specific AI implementation goal, with named tasks, named owners, and a named timeline, to that existing table instead of building a parallel one. Where no such structure exists at your campus, present the same specific plan directly to your principal. Either way the substance is identical: named tasks, named owners, named deadlines, not a vision document. This is also how the role scales in a multi-campus district: each campus ACIL works through whatever structure exists at their campus and reports to their campus principal, not to a superintendent managing 100 direct reports.

For multi-campus districts: name a District AI Coordinator

One central role, not a second layer of management, who aggregates what each campus ACIL reports through the improvement-planning process, keeps the resource library current across campuses, and holds a standing agenda item with district curriculum leadership. This person reports to the Chief Academic Officer or the superintendent's designee. A hundred campus leads still report locally. Only their rolled-up progress moves to the district level.

LESSONS-LEARNED DOCUMENTATION: REQUIRED, NOT OPTIONAL

The two-year cycle only compounds value if each round builds on the last. Without documentation, every cycle starts from zero.

Every ACIL produces a structured lessons-learned document at the end of Year 1 and at the two-year review. It is a required deliverable, filed in the district resource library and handed directly to their successor. The format: what worked and why, what failed and why, what surprised us about faculty resistance or student responses, what we would cut if we did it again, what we would start earlier, which resources were most and least used.

Without this document, the institutional knowledge from two years of implementation evaporates when the ACIL rotates. The cycle is only worth running if each iteration is smarter than the last, and that requires written continuity.

SUCCESSION PLANNING: DO THIS BEFORE YOU NEED IT

The most common implementation failure: a strong ACIL leaves after 14–18 months (underpaid, overloaded, recruited elsewhere), and the program dies because everything lived in their head and their relationships. Prevent this structurally, not reactively.

- **Name a deputy ACIL by month 6.** Not a backup. A co-participant who attends all meetings, owns at least one deliverable, and can step into the role with 4–6 weeks of overlap transition.
- **Build a shared, wiki-style resource library, not one person's Google Drive.** All PD materials, lesson plans, policy templates, and vendor contacts live in an institutionally owned repository. The ACIL contributes to it. They don't own it. When they leave, the library stays.
- **Quarterly workload audits.** The ACIL task list is substantial. At 90 days, 180 days, and annually, review which functions are being sustained, which have slipped, and whether the role design needs adjustment. An honest workload audit prevents the slow-motion burnout that kills programs.
- **If the ACIL leaves, trigger the succession plan within 30 days.** Not eventually. Thirty days. The deputy steps in, the resource library continues, the PD calendar holds. The program is not allowed to go dormant while administration debates next steps.

A NOTE ON COLLECTIVE BARGAINING AND TEACHER ASSOCIATIONS

In Texas, collective bargaining for teachers is limited, but teacher associations still influence culture, policy, and adoption. In other states, mandatory PD requirements, stipends, and course assignment changes may be subject to collective bargaining agreements. Before announcing implementation timelines, review any applicable contracts or MOUs. AI implementation that feels unilaterally imposed on teachers will fail faster than any policy failure. Frame this as professional development and career protection, not compliance. Engage teacher association leadership early.

FOR RURAL DISTRICTS AND SMALL ISDS

The full ACIL model assumes institutional capacity not every district has. Your options: share a regional ACIL through your Education Service Center with neighboring districts. Or use the free AI4K12 and MIT Day of AI resources with a single volunteer teacher lead. Or focus Year 1 entirely on the teacher survey and the AI use policy, with no new courses and no new hires. A well-executed minimal implementation beats a half-implemented full model every time.

03 THE CURRICULUM VERDICT
What to Add, What to Reform, What to Kill

This section makes specific recommendations. Some of them will be uncomfortable, and that's intentional. The point of a document like this is to say what is genuinely needed, not what is politically easiest. The ACIL's job is to build the consensus to carry these out. Your job is to create the permission structure that lets them.

AN HONEST CAVEAT ON CURRICULUM SPECIFICS

These recommendations rest on current labor market research, expert consensus, and pedagogical evidence. State standards and local context matter. Some will require waiver processes, SBOE engagement, or curriculum committee approval. That's expected, and worth doing. None of them require you to invent anything: every recommended course and framework already exists and is running in leading districts.

Courses to add to the required curriculum

ADD **AI Foundations: one semester, required, grade 9 or 10**

This course barely exists anywhere. It needs to exist everywhere.

A required, one-semester introduction to artificial intelligence that every high school student completes by 10th grade. This is not a computer science elective. It is a foundational literacy course, like requiring English, not like offering AP Physics. The AI4K12 Five Big Ideas framework provides the curriculum scaffolding for free.

What this course covers:

- **How AI actually works, conceptually.** Students need to understand that AI is pattern recognition from data, not magic and not sentient understanding. That mental model prevents both uncritical trust and irrational fear.
- **How AI is trained, and what that means for bias and errors.** AI outputs reflect the data they were trained on. If the data has bias, the AI has bias. Students who understand this become better critics of AI output in every context.
- **Using AI tools as a productivity co-pilot, hands-on.** Students should leave this course having used at least 3–4 different AI tools on meaningful tasks: research assistance, writing support, data analysis, image generation. Actually used them, not just heard they exist.
- **Evaluating and fact-checking AI outputs as a core protocol.** AI confidently produces false information. That is a feature of how these systems work, not a temporary bug. Every student needs a repeatable verification protocol before leaving this course.
- **AI and the labor market: what's changing and why.** Students deserve honest, age-appropriate information about how AI is reshaping the job market they're about to enter. That's not scaremongering. That's career counseling.
- **The ethics of AI: who benefits, who is harmed, who decides.** Algorithmic bias, surveillance, data privacy, and AI in criminal justice are not abstract topics. These are systems your students already live under. They should understand them.

> **Free curriculum resources:** AI4K12 (ai4k12.org) provides grade-band progression charts and curriculum materials aligned to this course scope at no cost. MIT's Day of AI (dayofai.org) provides free lesson plans built for high school classrooms. Do not build this from scratch.

ADD Computer Science Principles: from AP elective to standard requirement

Currently an AP option. It should be a standard diploma requirement at the non-AP level.

CSP covers computational thinking, data, the internet, algorithms, and programming, all foundational to understanding AI. It already exists as a College Board AP course. A non-AP version of CSP should be a graduation requirement, not a reward for academically advanced students. Every student should understand how code and data systems work, even if they never write a line of code professionally.

Districts that can't implement this immediately should at minimum offer CSP as a free elective with active counselor encouragement rather than a gated AP-only option, and track enrollment by demographic to identify access gaps.

ADD "Future of Work" senior elective: one semester, grades 11–12

An honest conversation about the economy they're about to enter.

A senior-year elective combining labor economics, career strategy, and applied AI skills. Students analyze labor market projections, audit their own career interests against automation risk, build professional AI tool portfolios, and develop the personal brand and adaptability skills that AI-era employers value. This is not career day. This is structured preparation for economic reality.

This course can be co-developed with local employer partners and community college faculty, which takes much of the development burden off your teaching staff.

Courses to dissolve or fundamentally reform

REFORM Standalone "keyboarding" courses

Basic keyboard fluency belongs in middle school. High school time should build on it.

Basic keyboarding should be mastered at the middle school level so high school can build on that foundation instead of repeating it. The time currently allocated to standalone typing courses in high school could be developing AI Foundations, computer science, or AI-augmented productivity skills. Voice-to-text, AI-assisted writing, and multimodal interfaces are steadily reducing the standalone strategic value of typing speed.

> **If you teach keyboarding or business technology:** your expertise is central to what comes next, not obsolete. The teachers who understand basic tech fluency and professional office skills are the natural leaders for rebuilding these courses around AI-augmented productivity. "How do you use AI to accomplish professional tasks?" is a direct evolution of "How do you use software to accomplish professional tasks?" We are not eliminating your course. We are elevating it.

REFORM Basic Microsoft Office / business technology courses: rebuild toward AI-augmented productivity

The skills matter. The scope needs to grow.

Courses built around basic software operation, formatting Word documents, making slides, basic Excel, teach real workplace skills. The issue is scope, not value. Students who graduate knowing these tools operationally but who have never used AI to augment their productivity are entering workplaces where AI-assisted workflows are already standard. Rebuild these courses around AI-augmented professional productivity: how to use AI to accomplish professional tasks faster and better, how to prompt effectively, how to evaluate and edit AI output, and how to build professional workflows with modern tools. The existing tools still belong in the course. They're the baseline, not the ceiling.

For business technology teachers: you already teach the most job-relevant course in the building. Adding AI productivity tools is a natural expansion, not a replacement. You're in the best position to lead this.

REFORM Career exploration courses using pre-2022 labor data: rebuild from the ground up

If your career curriculum hasn't been updated since before GPT-4, it is actively misinforming students.

Any course or counseling material that describes stable career paths in administrative support, customer service, basic accounting, data entry, paralegal work, or entry-level finance without addressing AI's impact on those fields

is giving students false information. This is not neutral. It is misleading. Every career pathway description, interest inventory, and counseling resource needs updating with current WEF, BLS, and McKinsey labor market projections. Your ACIL should own this audit, and it should be done in the first semester.

What to add to existing courses, subject by subject

Not every AI integration requires a new course. Most of it belongs inside what teachers already do. The additions below are specific enough to assign to departments, not vague enough to ignore.

English / ELA

- Unit: critical evaluation of AI-generated text. How to identify AI writing, fact-check claims, evaluate the sources AI cites.
- AI-assisted editing with required transparency: students document which AI suggestions they accepted, rejected, and why.
- Research paper evolution: how to use AI for literature synthesis while applying their own analytical argument.
- The rhetoric of AI: how AI shapes persuasion in advertising, political content, and recommendation algorithms.
- Replace some traditional research papers with annotated process portfolios showing the AI interaction.

Science

- Unit: how AI is used in scientific research. Drug discovery, climate modeling, genomics, astronomy.
- Data collection projects using AI tools to analyze results, then a critique of what the AI missed or misread.
- Unit: reproducibility and AI. What happens when AI is trained on flawed data, using real case studies.
- The ethics of AI in science: who owns AI-generated discoveries, and how AI-assisted research should be attributed.
- Lab reports: require one section on how AI tools could or could not assist the experiment, and why.

Social Studies / History

- Unit: AI and labor. Connect current AI disruption to historical automation waves, from the Industrial Revolution to computers displacing typists.
- Unit: AI and democracy. Algorithmic content curation, deepfakes, election interference, surveillance capitalism.
- Unit: AI and global power. US-China AI competition, who controls AI infrastructure, and why it matters.
- Unit: who builds AI? The demographics of the tech workforce and what that means for whose values AI reflects.
- Current events component: monthly AI news analysis using primary sources.

Mathematics

- Integrate data literacy throughout: every statistics unit should include real-world AI datasets.
- Probability and uncertainty, directly foundational to understanding why AI makes errors.
- Algebra II / Pre-Calc: introduce the concept of optimization algorithms without heavy coding.
- Statistics: "What do these numbers actually say?" applied to AI performance claims in news articles.
- Replace some abstract word problems with labor market data problems (WEF data, BLS projections).

Career & Technical Education (CTE)

- Every CTE pathway must include a "How AI is changing this field" unit: specific, current, not generic.
- Business CTE: AI-augmented business operations, customer service AI, data analysis tools.
- Health Science CTE: AI in diagnostics, medical imaging, electronic health records, drug discovery.
- Agriculture CTE: precision agriculture AI, crop yield prediction, drone and sensor technology.
- Arts/Media CTE: generative AI in creative fields. What it does, what it can't do, ethical use.
- Industry credential additions: Google Career Certificates and the AWS Educate pathway, offered in CTE tracks.

Fine Arts / Electives

- Art: AI image tools. What they are, how they're trained on human art, and the ethics of copyright and compensation.
- Music: AI music generation. Practical exposure plus discussion of creative authenticity.
- Drama/Media: deepfakes, synthetic voices, AI in filmmaking, practical and ethical dimensions.
- Journalism: AI in news production, fact-checking AI-generated news, synthetic media detection.
- All electives: "How is AI affecting this field professionally?" At minimum, one unit per course.

04

DESIGN RATIONALE

Why This Toolkit Is Built the Way It Is

Every structural recommendation in this document traces to a specific finding in cognitive science research. This section is not a primer on learning theory. It's the answer to "why does the toolkit tell us to do it this way" for anyone who asks, including the curriculum director who will ask, and should.

Structural choices and their evidence base

What we recommend	The research finding behind it
AI literacy is distributed across all four years, not concentrated in one course.	**Spaced practice.** Learning distributed over time produces substantially better retention than the same content delivered in one block. A single AI course in 9th grade produces students who once knew this material.

What we recommend	The research finding behind it
AI skills are taught in English, science, social studies, and math, not siloed.	**Interleaving and transfer.** Skills practiced in one context rarely transfer to new ones automatically. A student who has critically evaluated AI outputs in four different subjects will do it on the job. A student who did it once in "AI class" will not.
Zone 2 requires an independent first attempt before AI access.	**Desirable difficulty.** Tasks requiring genuine cognitive effort produce durable learning. Removing that effort feels like help and isn't. The 10–15 minute independent attempt is where the learning happens. AI applied after that point amplifies thinking. Applied before it, AI replaces thinking.
The AI Contribution Statement is required, and asks what the AI got wrong.	**Metacognition.** Students who monitor their own thinking outperform those who don't, across every subject and age group. The statement is a metacognitive instrument that happens to look like a disclosure form. That is deliberate.
The AI Foundations course opens with real AI failures, not with how neural networks work.	**Concrete before abstract.** Students grasp abstract principles better after concrete cases. "Here is an AI that misdiagnosed this scan. Why?" produces better understanding than starting with architecture diagrams.
Faculty PD is sequenced in 4–6 week increments, never one all-day session.	**Cognitive load.** Working memory has hard limits. Ten new tools introduced in one PD day produces shallow processing, rapid forgetting, and a faculty room that has decided AI is overwhelming. One tool, practiced, assessed, then the next.
Low-stakes AI literacy checks are built into every course, not saved for a summative test.	**Retrieval practice.** Recalling from memory strengthens learning more than re-reading. Five minutes of "name one AI limitation relevant to today's task" is a learning event, not an assessment event.
Oral defense is the verification mechanism throughout this document.	**Retrieval under authentic conditions.** A student who cannot explain their own argument in conversation has not learned it, whether or not AI was involved. That's why oral defense shows up in the AI-Free track, in Zone 2 verification, and in assessment redesign. One mechanism, three jobs.

> "In education, it means protecting the struggle: letting students wrestle with problems before offering AI assistance, creating spaces where the friction of figuring things out is the point rather than an inefficiency to eliminate."
>
> HELEN EDWARDS, AI RESEARCHER · ITDF HUMAN RESILIENCE REPORT, 2026

05

FACULTY DEVELOPMENT

The Full Professional Development Plan

Faculty can't teach what they don't understand, and they won't engage deeply with PD that feels imposed, irrelevant, or condescending. The plan below is substantive enough to build real competency and structured enough to sustain without burning anyone out.

> One-day PD sessions produce minimal behavior change. Everything in this plan requires sustained engagement over weeks, not a single workshop. If your PD budget only allows one day, spend it differently: use the time to train the ACIL and let them run a sustained program.

Phase 1: foundation training, all faculty

Semester 1 · roughly 8–10 hours total across 6 weeks

Weeks 1–2: complete Google's "Generative AI for Educators" course (free, 2 hours)

grow.google/ai-for-educators. This is the minimum viable foundation: how generative AI works, how to use it responsibly, and practical classroom applications. Self-paced and free. Assign it as homework before the first group session.

Week 3: group session, "AI in My Classroom: Exploring Tools Together" (2 hours)

Facilitated by the ACIL. Teachers spend this session actually using AI tools in the context of their subject area, not watching a demo. English teachers try AI for essay feedback. Science teachers try it for data analysis. Math teachers try it for problem generation. Hands-on, with peer discussion and no judgment about comfort level.

Week 4: individual exploration, "Assign one AI-integrated lesson this month"

Each teacher designs and delivers one lesson that meaningfully incorporates AI, either as a tool students use or as a subject students analyze, and documents the outcome. The ACIL checks in individually to troubleshoot and support. This is where theory becomes practice.

Weeks 5–6: group debrief, "What worked, what didn't, what students taught us" (2 hours)

Each teacher shares their lesson experience: the success, the failure, and the surprise. This peer learning is worth more than any training session. The ACIL documents what worked and seeds those lessons as models for the next cohort.

> **Assessment:** faculty demonstrate one AI-integrated unit to a peer before Phase 2. Completing Phase 1 is not clicking through a course. It's demonstrating that you can design and deliver an AI-integrated lesson. Peer demonstration, not a test. That creates accountability without surveillance.

Phase 2: learning communities, ongoing, by subject area

Semester 2 forward · monthly, subject-area cohorts of 4–6 teachers

After foundation training, the ongoing PD model is peer learning communities organized by subject area. Each community meets monthly for 60–90 minutes. The agenda is simple: share one thing you tried with AI, discuss what students did with it, review one new resource or tool, and set one goal for next month.

- **The ACIL facilitates communities in Semester 2, then hands off to community leaders.** By the second year, each learning community should have an internally identified leader running the monthly session. The ACIL attends quarterly as a resource and connector, not as the facilitator of every meeting.
- **Communities share resources through a shared, curated folder.** The ACIL maintains a district-wide resource folder organized by subject area. Teachers contribute AI-integrated lesson plans, rubrics, and policy language. This institutional knowledge survives teacher turnover.
- **Annual cross-community share-out: "What we built this year."** At the end of each year, every learning community presents one AI-integrated unit they developed. Recorded for the district resource library and celebrated publicly. That creates positive social proof and raises the visibility of the people doing the work.

Compensation and incentives

Faculty who develop excellent AI-integrated curriculum are doing curriculum development work. Expecting that on top of a full teaching load with no recognition is how good initiatives die. Even small compensation signals that the work is valued.

What to offer

- $500–$2,000 internal curriculum development grant for faculty who build AI-integrated units adopted district-wide
- Recognition in the annual AI Readiness Report, with named credit for innovation
- Priority for conference attendance and professional development funding for AI education events
- Letters of support for grant applications that include AI integration work
- A public board presentation opportunity for teachers doing exceptional AI innovation work

Free PD resources for faculty

- Generative AI for Educators (Google + MIT RAISE): grow.google/ai-for-educators (free, self-paced)
- MIT Day of AI: dayofai.org (free K–12 curriculum plus teacher training)
- AI4K12 educator resources: ai4k12.org/resources (free, CSTA-backed)
- OpenAI Academy: free training for educators, with community college partnerships

06

GOVERNANCE

The Three-Zone AI Use Policy Framework

Blanket bans teach students that AI is something to hide from authority figures, which is not a life skill. Blanket permission leaves students without judgment and reduces learning. Every district needs a specific, enforceable policy that faculty can actually apply consistently. The Three-Zone Framework is that policy.

> **UNESCO'S POSITION: SET A MINIMUM AGE FOR INDEPENDENT USE**
>
> UNESCO's 2023 global guidance on generative AI in education recommends a minimum age of 13 for independent, unsupervised use of GenAI platforms, with acknowledgment that the EU's GDPR sets the threshold at 16. The reasoning: younger students lack the developmental capacity to critically evaluate AI outputs, recognize hallucinations, or maintain appropriate skepticism about generated content. Below 13, AI tools should only be used in structured, teacher-supervised contexts with explicit pedagogical framing, never as independent productivity tools.
>
> **This toolkit adopts the UNESCO minimum: no independent, unsupervised use of GenAI platforms for students under 13.** Supervised use in deliberately designed AI literacy lessons is permitted at any grade level with appropriate scaffolding.

The risk nobody is naming: cognitive surrender

Academic integrity policies focus on cheating: students using AI to produce work they claim is their own. That's a real problem. But UNESCO and subsequent research from the Wharton School (Shaw & Nave, 2026) identify a separate, harder-to-detect risk: **cognitive surrender**, where students accept AI outputs without critically processing them, even when they're technically compliant with the assignment's rules. A student who uses AI to outline an essay, accepts the structure without questioning it, fills in the prose without interrogating the framing, and submits a technically disclosed but intellectually passive product has not cheated. They have also not learned anything.

UNESCO puts it directly: "GenAI should not be allowed to usurp human thinking." Your Three-Zone policy needs to address demonstrated independent reasoning, not just disclosure. The AI Contribution Statement below is built to require it. The oral defense component in the AI-Free Declaration Track is the strongest practical check against it. And Zone 2 assignments on high-stakes work should require students to explain, not just disclose.

Zone 1: AI-Free

No AI tools of any kind. Human cognition only.

Examples: first drafts of personal essays, in-class exams, oral presentations, hands-on labs, creative brainstorming sessions.

Zone 2: AI-Transparent

AI tools may be used with full disclosure.

For high-stakes assignments, students must complete an independent first draft before using AI, and must demonstrate understanding through an in-class check, a process portfolio, or a brief oral review.

Examples: research projects, revised drafts, data analysis tasks, complex research synthesis. Requires an AI Contribution Statement plus evidence of independent thinking, not just disclosure.

Zone 3: AI-Collaborative

AI tool use is the explicit learning objective.

Students practice using AI effectively and critically.

Examples: AI Foundations course activities, AI-augmented productivity lessons, critical evaluation exercises, tool comparison projects.

The AI Contribution Statement: use this in Zone 2 assignments

Students attach this to any work where AI assistance was used.

> AI CONTRIBUTION STATEMENT
>
> 1. Which AI tool(s) did I use for this assignment?
> 2. What specifically did I ask the AI to help with?
> 3. What did I change or reject from what the AI provided?
> 4. What parts of this work are entirely my own, without AI assistance?
> 5. What did the AI get wrong or miss that I had to correct?
> 6. How did using AI change how I approached this task?

This statement is a metacognitive tool. Students who complete it regularly develop the self-awareness that AI-era employers call "AI judgment." Make it a habit, not a punishment.

The AI-Free Declaration Track: for students with principled ethical objections

A recognized alternative pathway. Not a punishment, not a reward.

A growing number of students, particularly at the secondary level, are declining to use AI tools on ethical grounds: the environmental cost of AI inference (water consumption and carbon), labor exploitation in training data annotation, copyright violations in training datasets, and concern about job displacement in creative fields. These are documented, legitimate concerns grounded in real evidence. Dismissing them, or penalizing the students who hold them, is both intellectually dishonest and counterproductive.

The conversation these students need, and are not currently getting, is not "you're wrong about the harms." It's this: ethical people opting out of a technology does not reduce that technology's power or adoption. It removes the most thoughtful users from the room where the tool is being deployed. The students who understand AI's harms most deeply are the ones who most need to be in the conversations about how it gets used.

Implementation:

- **The student formally declares AI-free status at the start of each semester, in writing, on file.** Not a sworn oath requiring surveillance. A formal acknowledgment that the student has chosen this track and understands its requirements. Filed with the ACIL and the relevant teacher.
- **All major assignments include a mandatory oral defense component.** A student who used AI to draft an essay and memorized it can pass a written integrity check. A ten-minute conversation with a teacher who knows the subject is much harder to fake than a written integrity check. The oral defense is the proposed verification mechanism, not a sworn statement, not an honor pledge. It is also, I would argue, better pedagogy than a written test.

- **Rubrics explicitly reward demonstrated reasoning and process, not polished prose.** AI produces cleaner prose than humans working under deadline pressure. That should never be the measure of learning, and it should never be the criterion that penalizes a student for working without AI.
- **Transcript notation: "Demonstrated Unassisted Mastery" on qualifying work.** No extra credit, because rewarding the absence of a tool implies AI use is inherently lesser. Instead, students who complete the AI-Free track with oral defenses intact receive a formal notation on their academic record. Colleges may well notice. Some will actively value it.
- **Students get explicit, honest instruction on the labor market implications of their choice.** Not to shame the decision. To inform it. A student choosing AI-free status deserves the honest version: here is the wage premium currently attached to AI fluency, here is how hiring is changing in your field of interest, here is what this choice costs you competitively and what it doesn't. They're entitled to make an informed decision, which means giving them the information, not withholding it to avoid discomfort. Students who understand the tradeoff and choose anyway are exercising genuine agency. That deserves respect.

AI detection software: read this before any teacher uses it

District policy required. This is a real civil rights exposure.

AI detection tools do not work reliably, and they fail hardest on the students your district is most obligated to protect. A 2023 Stanford study published in *Patterns* tested seven widely used detectors against 91 TOEFL essays written by non-native English speakers. Average false positive rate: 61.3%. On a control set of essays by native English-speaking US eighth graders, the same detectors were near-perfect. Ninety-eight percent of the non-native essays were flagged by at least one detector. Every one of those essays was written by a human.

Independent testing consistently finds higher false positive rates for non-native English speakers than for native speakers. Early research also reports detectors misclassifying autistic writing as AI-generated at elevated rates, and students with ADHD or dyslexia often write with the repeated phrasing and consistent sentence structures these tools score as machine-generated. Treat that evidence as emerging, not settled. Students who use Grammarly for proofreading have also been flagged, because grammar correction smooths out the irregularities detectors read as human.

The consequences are real. A University of North Georgia student was given a zero, placed on academic probation, and lost her HOPE Scholarship eligibility after Turnitin flagged a paper she wrote herself, using Grammarly only for proofreading. Universities including Vanderbilt and Yale have restricted or disabled these tools after reviewing how they perform.

Required district policy:

- **Detector output may never be the sole basis for an academic integrity accusation.** Write this into the student code of conduct. A percentage score from a detection tool is not evidence. It's a probability estimate from a system with a documented 61% error rate on ESL writing. Any accusation must rest on process evidence: version history, draft progression, an oral conversation about the work.

- **Teachers receive training on detector limitations before being given access.** A teacher who believes a 92% score means a 92% likelihood of cheating will act on that belief. This training is not optional and should be delivered by the ACIL before any detection tool is deployed. Include the Stanford false positive data explicitly.
- **Any flagged work triggers a conversation, not a grade penalty.** The conversation is the actual assessment: ask the student to explain their argument, walk through their sources, describe how they got from the prompt to the conclusion. A student who wrote the work can do this. A student who didn't can't. It takes ten minutes, and it tests understanding directly, which is more than detection software can claim.
- **ELL students, students with IEPs, and students with 504 plans require documented additional review.** The research is strongest for non-native English speakers, and early studies point the same way for autistic writers. For students with IEPs and 504 plans, treat this extra review as a recommended safeguard, not a research finding. Your district's legal exposure on a disparate impact claim is real. If detection tools are used at all, flagged work from these students requires a second reviewer and documented process evidence before any action.
- **Log every detector-initiated accusation and review the demographics annually.** If flagged students are disproportionately ELL, disproportionately receiving special education services, or disproportionately students of color, treat that pattern as a signal to investigate the tool and how it is being used, not as proof of discrimination by itself. A skew like that is what a disparate-impact review looks for, and you will only see it if you count. The ACIL owns this review.

TEACHERS USING AI TO GRADE STUDENT WORK

Some teachers are already using AI tools to grade or give feedback on student assignments. This needs district guidance before it becomes a problem, not after.

Uploading student work to an AI tool can create a FERPA-covered disclosure, and the details matter. FERPA covers records directly related to an identifiable student and maintained by the school. A photographed handwritten essay with the student's name on it qualifies once the school keeps it. Disclosing it to a third party generally requires parent or eligible-student consent, unless a specific exception applies, like the school-official exception for vendors performing a school function under the district's direct control. Whether a specific upload violates FERPA depends on the facts: what identifies the student, whether consent exists, and how much control the district actually has over the tool. Have counsel review any tool before student work goes into it. The safe district rule: no identifiable student work enters any AI tool without a signed data agreement.

What district policy should require: AI-assisted grading only through tools on the approved list with signed data agreements. Student identifying information comes out before any upload. The teacher makes and owns the final grade determination in every case. Students are told when AI is used in evaluating their work. AI can reasonably help a teacher draft feedback language, check a rubric application for consistency, or spot patterns across a class set. It cannot assign the grade. The professional judgment stays with the human whose name is on the gradebook.

Assessment must change

If an AI can trivially complete your assignment, the assignment no longer measures what students know. That doesn't mean eliminating written assignments. It means redesigning them so the learning can't be outsourced.

> **UNESCO'S FOUR-CATEGORY FRAMEWORK FOR LEARNING OUTCOMES IN THE AI ERA**
>
> UNESCO's 2023 guidance proposes four categories of learning outcomes that stay meaningful when GenAI can produce competent essays and pass standard tests. Use them as a design lens:
>
> - **Values.** Human-centered design and use of technology. Does the student understand when AI should and shouldn't be used, and why?
> - **Foundational knowledge and skills.** Literacy, numeracy, core domain knowledge. Still essential. AI doesn't replace the need to actually know things. It raises the bar for what "knowing" must produce.
> - **Higher-order thinking skills.** Critical evaluation of AI outputs, source verification, recognizing hallucination and bias. Now a core skill, not a bonus.
> - **Vocational and professional skills.** Effective collaboration with AI tools in real work contexts. Students who can use AI as a thinking partner rather than a shortcut are the ones employers compete for.
>
> The implication: a redesign effort focused only on catching AI-assisted cheating asks the wrong question. The right question is whether your assessments measure any of these four categories, or only the thing AI can produce: polished, plausible-sounding text.

AI-vulnerable assessments	AI-resistant assessments
✗ Take-home essays with broad prompts ("Discuss the causes of WWI")	✓ Oral defenses of written work, where the student must explain every claim
✗ Research summaries without documented process	✓ Portfolios with annotated revision history showing process
✗ Multiple choice tests on factual recall (lower-order Bloom's)	✓ Timed in-class writing on class-specific, unpredictable prompts
✗ Generic problem sets students can photograph and ask AI to solve	✓ Problem-solving demonstrations while the teacher observes
✗ Book reports or article summaries without class-specific context	✓ Projects tied to local, specific contexts that AI has no data on

WHY DETECTION SOFTWARE IS NOT AN ENFORCEMENT PLAN

In a blind test at the University of Reading, 100% AI-written exam submissions were injected into real undergraduate psychology modules. 94% went undetected, 97% under a stricter definition. The AI answers also earned higher grades on average than real student work (Scarfe et al., PLOS ONE, June 2024).

Detectors also err in the other direction, flagging honest students, as the Stanford TOEFL data above shows. A policy built on a detector punishes some honest students and misses many who cheat.

Build the policy on clear zones, disclosure, and assessment design. Use detector results only to start a conversation, never as proof.

Design assessments assuming AI is in the room

A personal prompt is not safe from AI: a reflection or a "write about your own experience" task can be done by a chatbot, and tools built to cheat on live tests exist. Safer designs: work done partly in class, oral check-ins about the student's own work, drafts with version history, and assignments that make students explain and defend their reasoning. Match the zone (AI-Free, AI-Transparent, AI-Collaborative) to the task, and say so on the assignment.

Why the AI-Free track is worth offering

In a survey of 319 knowledge workers, people who reported more confidence in generative AI reported using less critical thinking effort, while people with more confidence in their own skills reported more (Lee et al., CHI 2025). The results are self-reported, so they show association, not proof. They're still a fair reason to keep a path where students practice thinking without AI.

07 REQUIRED SAFEGUARDS

Student Data Privacy & AI Vendor Compliance

No student-facing AI tool should be in your district without this framework in place first. This isn't a legal technicality. It's the condition every other recommendation in this toolkit operates under. One board member asking "what vendors, what data, what protections" without a documented answer can table the entire adoption vote.

Who owns technical vetting	Minimum technical bar for any approved tool
Your IT director or CTO/CIO, not the ACIL. The ACIL owns pedagogy: whether a tool serves learning. IT owns the technical evaluation: uptime history, security patching cadence, whether the vendor has had a breach, and whether the tool integrates safely with your student information system. These are two different jobs, and a tool needs sign-off from both before it reaches the approved list.	Encryption of student data at rest and in transit. Role-based access controls, so a teacher cannot see another teacher's class data. A documented incident response process from the vendor. A public security audit or SOC 2 report less than 18 months old. If a vendor cannot produce these on request, the tool does not go on the list, regardless of how good the product is.

Non-negotiable vendor and data requirements

Complete this before any classroom AI tool goes live.

- **FERPA compliance confirmed in writing for every AI tool that touches student work.** If a teacher photographs a student's handwritten essay and uploads it to an AI grading tool, that can be a disclosure of a FERPA-covered education record once the work identifies the student. "We use it informally" is not a defense. District policy should require a signed data agreement for every AI tool that touches identifiable student work.
- **Prohibited data types, defined and communicated to all staff.** The following may never be uploaded to any unapproved AI tool: IEP information, 504 accommodation plans, health records, behavioral discipline records, mental health disclosures, personally identifiable information. These require explicit legal review and parental consent that standard tool use doesn't provide.
- **Vendor data-use agreements must prohibit training models on student work.** Many free AI tools improve their models on user-submitted content. Student writing is not training data for a private company's product. Vendor contracts must say so explicitly. If they won't sign that clause, the tool doesn't go in classrooms.
- **An approved tools list, maintained by the ACIL and published to staff.** Teachers should not be independently picking AI tools for classroom use. An approved list, vetted by the ACIL, reviewed by legal counsel, and updated annually, gives teachers the framework they need and the district the protection it needs.
- **An incident response protocol for accidental uploads of protected information.** Assume it will happen: a teacher uploads a document containing a student's accommodation information or last name. Write the protocol before it happens: who is notified, what the vendor is asked to do, how parents are informed, what gets documented.
- **A parent-facing, plain-language summary of which AI tools are used and how.** The parent who asks "which AI tools are reading my child's work?" deserves a plain-language answer, not a legal document. One page, accessible language, updated annually. Put it in the back-to-school packet.

Student learning data is not raw material for vendor product development. Say it in every vendor agreement. Say it publicly in your district AI policy. If a parent, board member, or journalist asks whether student data is being used to train AI models, your answer needs to be documented and clear.

THE RIGHT-TO-ERASURE PROBLEM: SOMETHING YOUR VENDOR AGREEMENT CANNOT FULLY SOLVE

UNESCO's guidance raises a data privacy issue with no clean contractual solution: once a student's personal data is embedded in a trained AI model, it cannot be cleanly removed. That directly conflicts with GDPR's right to be forgotten and with various US state privacy laws that give individuals the right to request deletion of their data.

Your vendor contract can prohibit training on student data. It cannot undo training that already happened. So your approved tools list must require vendors to document in writing whether any student data has ever been used in model training, and what their technical controls are to prevent it going forward. Tools that can't provide that documentation don't belong on your list. That's the difference between a vendor saying they protect privacy and a vendor demonstrating it.

Ongoing monitoring: annual re-validation, not just onboarding

UNESCO calls for ongoing monitoring and validation of AI systems, not a one-time privacy review at adoption. Build it into the ACIL's annual calendar: once a year, every approved tool is re-evaluated for changes to data practices, terms of service, model updates that may affect output quality or bias, and student-facing interface changes that affect age-appropriateness. A tool that met your standards in Year 1 may not meet them in Year 2. Vendors update their terms quietly. Make re-evaluation a standing requirement, not a response to incidents.

Special education and students with disabilities	Late-career teachers
AI tools create real accessibility opportunities for students with disabilities: text-to-speech, adaptive scaffolding, multimodal content, executive function support. They also create real risks. IEP and accommodation data must never be uploaded to unapproved tools. AI-generated differentiated materials require human review before use. Assistive AI tools must meet WCAG 2.1 accessibility standards. Students using AI-based assistive technology should not be penalized under academic integrity policies. And oral defense verification for the AI-Free track must have documented alternatives for students with speech or hearing impairments. Special education staff must be included in any AI tool adoption process that affects their students.	Not every teacher will become an AI integration champion, and that's okay. Some of your most respected, most effective educators are 5–8 years from retirement and have neither the bandwidth nor the motivation to redesign their entire curriculum. Forcing integration produces bad integration and resentment. What you need from every teacher: understand the district's AI use policy, don't use unapproved tools with student data, and participate in baseline literacy PD. Beyond that, pairing late-career teachers with AI-curious colleagues produces better outcomes than top-down compliance pressure.

POLITICAL RISK IN TEXAS: KNOW YOUR LANDSCAPE

Texas SB 382 (89th Legislature, 2025) was introduced to prohibit school districts from using AI technology to provide instruction to students. It was referred to committee and did not advance, but it signals a political environment in which AI in education is contested. If your district adopts this toolkit and the political climate shifts, your best protection is a documented governance framework: AI is taught as a subject of critical study, AI tools support teachers rather than replace them, parents were consulted before adoption, and all student data protections are documented. That's not just good policy. In Texas in 2026, it's armor.

08

PAYING FOR IT

What This Costs and Where the Money Can Come From

The lead role is the main cost. The toolkit's own estimate is 1 to 2 release periods per semester plus a stipend of $2,000 to $4,000, and the real cost with substitute coverage runs $12,000 to $30,000 or more a year. Size the commitment to match the mandate you give the role. A role with no protected time won't last.

Federal formula money you may already receive

Title II-A (educator professional development) and Title IV-A (technology and professional development) can fund parts of this. In July 2025 the U.S. Department of Education issued guidance on using federal grant funds for responsible AI integration. Ask your federal programs director what your allocation allows. Allowable use depends on your plan and your state.

Share the cost

Education Service Centers (ESCs) in Texas offer AI training, and some offer paid AI implementation services. Small districts can share one lead through their ESC. Prices and terms vary, so ask your region.

> **Don't spend money first.** Tier 1 costs staff time only. Prove the survey and the policy work before you pay for a stipend, a vendor, or a consultant.

Sources: U.S. Department of Education, Dear Colleague Letter, July 22, 2025 · Title IV-A program profile · ESC Region 16 2026-27 service contract (AI implementation service). These describe general rules. Confirm with your own finance office.

09

CAREER PATHWAY MODERNIZATION

What Your Counselors Must Know, and How to Get Them There

Counselor AI labor market training: required annually. Not optional. Your counselors are your students' first line of career intelligence.

- **Annual training using the WEF Future of Jobs Report and the BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook.** Counselors review both sources at the start of every school year, looking specifically for which occupational categories are growing, which are shrinking, and what skills are most in demand. This is not a one-time training. It's an annual practice. Schedule it in August before students arrive.
- **Build an AI-risk profile for the top 20 careers students in your district most commonly pursue.** What are your students' most-chosen career interests? Counselors should be able to tell each student: here is the current automation risk profile for that career, here is what's growing within it, and here are the skills that make you more valuable in that field. This requires research, and the ACIL can help source it. It should be on every counseling wall.
- **Partner with at least 5 local employers annually for honest "what do you actually need from our graduates?" conversations.** Not speakers at career day. Structured conversations with HR staff and direct

managers who review entry-level applications. Their feedback should directly inform what counselors tell students and what teachers emphasize. Schedule these in the fall and share findings in the spring.

- **Offer AI-relevant industry credentials through the counseling office, and track enrollment.** Google Career Certificates, AWS Educate, Microsoft Fundamentals: free or low-cost, employer-recognized, and achievable in a semester. Counselors should know how to access them, how to recommend them, and which students complete them. This is a graduation differentiator that costs almost nothing to offer.
- **Create "AI in My Field" job shadow experiences with local employers, minimum 2 per year.** Most students can't picture what AI integration looks like in a real workplace. A structured one-day experience at a local healthcare organization, law firm, accounting office, or manufacturing facility, where students watch AI tools in actual use, changes how they think about career preparation. The ACIL coordinates this through the employer advisory council.

10 THE FULL TIMELINE

The Two-Year Cycle: Implement, Review, Start Over

This is not a one-time project. AI capabilities and labor market conditions are moving faster than traditional curriculum review cycles. The model below is a two-year implementation cycle that repeats, each round building on the last, each review informed by student outcomes and labor market changes. This is your district's new normal.

Every two years: audit what changed, revise what didn't work, update what became outdated, and celebrate what actually moved students forward.

Year 1: foundation and launch

Q1 AUG–OCT Appoint, audit, and announce

- Name and announce the ACIL publicly: board meeting, staff email, community newsletter
- ACIL completes the AI readiness survey of all faculty
- ACIL audits all existing AI-related curriculum and creates the gap map
- Superintendent meets with 3–5 local employers to begin advisory council formation
- ACIL completes the Google and MIT foundation training courses
- Draft the district AI use policy framework (the Three-Zone model)

Q2 NOV–JAN Train faculty, pilot curriculum

- Phase 1 faculty PD begins for all instructional staff, in rolling 6-week cohorts
- AI use policy finalized and published to students, parents, and staff
- Family listening session held before the policy is finalized, not after: one evening session where parents ask questions and raise concerns directly, with what you hear fed into the final policy language
- Identify 2–3 teachers to pilot an AI Foundations mini-unit in existing courses (not a full course yet)
- Employer advisory council holds its first meeting, with counselors attending
- Counselor AI labor market training session (ACIL-led, 3 hours)
- Begin the dual enrollment conversation with the nearest community college for CSP access

Q3 FEB–APR Expand and document

- Phase 1 PD completes for all faculty, with completion rates documented
- Learning communities launch by subject area (monthly meetings begin)
- Pilot AI-integrated lessons collected into the district resource library
- First "AI in My Field" job shadow experience for 11th and 12th graders
- Identify which existing courses to reform: keyboarding, office tech, career exploration
- Begin curriculum planning for the AI Foundations standalone course (Year 2 launch)

Q4 MAY–JUL Evaluate and report

- ACIL produces the first annual AI Readiness Report, submitted to the board and published publicly
- Faculty survey re-administered and compared to baseline
- Student survey on AI literacy confidence and tool access
- Employer advisory council Year 1 feedback session: what gaps remain?
- Board presentation: what happened, what worked, what didn't, the Year 2 plan
- AI Foundations course curriculum finalized for the Year 2 launch

Year 2: deepen, scale, and institutionalize

Q1 AUG–OCT Launch AI Foundations and scale what worked

- AI Foundations course launches, at least one section per grade band (9th–10th)
- Phase 2 PD begins: deeper, subject-specific skill building for all faculty
- Keyboarding and obsolete courses formally dissolved or restructured, with board approval if needed
- Student AI Ethics Advisory Board formed (8–12 students, applications open)
- Industry credential enrollment begins (Google, AWS, Microsoft pathways in CTE)

Q2 NOV–JAN Employer integration and community communication

- Employer advisory council second meeting: a curriculum feedback session with department heads present
- Parent/community information session: "What We're Teaching About AI and Why"
- AI Foundations course mid-year review, adjusted on student and teacher feedback
- Learning communities now teacher-led (the ACIL attends quarterly, not monthly)
- Assessment redesign workshop for all departments, introducing AI-resistant assessment types

Q3 FEB–APR Senior "Future of Work" launch and credential completion

- Future of Work elective launches for 11th and 12th grade
- First cohort of students completes an industry credential (track completion rates by demographic)
- Job shadow experiences expanded to a minimum of 4 per year
- Student AI Ethics Advisory Board presents its first recommendations to administration
- ACIL begins planning for the two-year curriculum review cycle

Q4 MAY–JUL The two-year review: starting the cycle over

- Full curriculum audit: what changed in AI capabilities and the labor market since the Year 1 baseline?
- Review the AI Foundations course scope: does it still cover the right tools and concepts?
- Employer advisory council: are graduates showing up better prepared? What's still missing?
- Faculty survey, third administration: track the growth trajectory
- Year 2 AI Readiness Report published, comparing measurable outcomes to Year 1
- Set Year 3 targets: update, expand, or revise Year 1 and Year 2 programs based on evidence
- ACIL appointment renewed, or a new ACIL identified and onboarded with a full handoff

When you restart the two-year cycle, the question is not "did we implement our plan?" It's "are our students better prepared for the labor market than they were 24 months ago?" Let the answer drive what changes.

11

THE RESOURCE DIRECTORY

Everything You Need, Organized So You Can Find It

This is the reference library. Resources were selected for quality, relevance, and accessibility, and offerings change. Cost is marked on each entry. The ACIL should maintain this directory, re-check links and terms, and update it quarterly.

For curriculum and classroom instruction

FREE CURRICULUM · K–12 · GRADES 9–12 FOCUS

AI4K12 Initiative

CSTA and AAAI-backed national initiative. Provides the Five Big Ideas in AI framework, grade-band curriculum guidelines, and a curated directory of AI education resources. The gold standard for K–12 AI curriculum frameworks.

ai4k12.org

FREE TEACHER TRAINING · GOOGLE + MIT RAISE

Generative AI for Educators

Free, two-hour, self-paced course developed by Google in collaboration with MIT RAISE for middle and high school teachers: practical classroom applications, responsible use, and hands-on activities. No technical background required. Certificate on completion.

grow.google/ai-for-educators

FREE CURRICULUM · K–12 · MIT-BUILT

MIT Day of AI

Free AI literacy curriculum developed by MIT RAISE, with grade-banded materials from elementary through high school. Covers how AI works, social impacts, and hands-on activities. Teacher training available. Designed to be used without a CS background.

dayofai.org

FREE COURSE PLATFORM · STUDENT-FACING

Code.org AI Curriculum

Free, browser-based AI and machine learning curriculum for high school students. No coding experience required, with lesson plans and teacher guides included.

code.org/ai

FREE COURSES · STUDENT AND TEACHER FACING

Machine Learning for Kids

Free browser-based platform where students train machine learning models without coding. Builds an intuitive understanding of how AI learns from data. Excellent for AI Foundations course activities.

machinelearningforkids.co.uk

FREE AI LITERACY · K–12

Skill Struck AI Literacy

Free AI literacy curriculum covering how machines sense, learn, and make decisions. Includes teacher dashboards and student rosters. Skill Struck is offering its full K–12 AI course suite to districts at no cost for the 2026–27 school year.

skillstruck.com/ai-literacy

DIGITAL CITIZENSHIP · FREE · COMMON SENSE

Common Sense Media Digital Citizenship

Comprehensive digital citizenship curriculum with AI-specific modules on media literacy, data privacy, and algorithmic awareness. Free for educators, with a K–12 scope and sequence available.

commonsense.org/education

INDUSTRY CREDENTIALS · STUDENT-FACING · LOW COST

Google Career Certificates

Industry-recognized certificates in IT Support, Data Analytics, AI Essentials, and more, available through Coursera. Many districts can access these at low or no cost for high school students through workforce development funding.

grow.google/certificates

INDUSTRY CREDENTIALS · STUDENT-FACING · AMAZON · FREE

AWS Educate

Free cloud computing and AI skills platform for students ages 13 and up: career-aligned learning paths, badges, and connections to employment, with no credit card or AWS console account required. Covers machine learning fundamentals, cloud basics, and AI applications.

aws.amazon.com/education/awseducate

For labor market and career data

FLAGSHIP EMPLOYER SURVEY · FREE · GLOBAL

WEF Future of Jobs Report

Published by the World Economic Forum. The most recent edition is the Future of Jobs Report 2025. The most comprehensive global survey of employer AI adoption, job creation and displacement projections, and fastest-growing skills. Essential reading for counselors and the ACIL.

weforum.org/publications/future-of-jobs

ANNUAL DATA · FREE · U.S. GOVERNMENT

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook

The Bureau of Labor Statistics' free database of job growth projections, required skills, and median wages for hundreds of occupations, updated annually. Essential for counselor training and career curriculum updates.

bls.gov/ooh

RESEARCH REPORTS · FREE

ITDF Research Reports

Elon University's Imagining the Digital Future Center, the research base for this toolkit: reports on AI's impact on human capacities (2025), human resilience infrastructure (2026), and more. Free PDF downloads. Essential for board presentations.

imaginingthedigitalfuture.org

POLICY GUIDE · FREE · TEACHAI

TeachAI Policy Guidance

Free AI policy guidance for K–12 school districts: sample policy language, implementation guides, and a growing community of districts sharing AI integration experiences. Led by Code.org, ETS, ISTE, Khan Academy, and the World Economic Forum.

teachai.org

For administrator and board briefings

RESEARCH BRIEF · FREE · STATE GUIDANCE

Your State Education Agency AI Guidance

Most state education agencies (California, Texas, Massachusetts, and others) have published AI-in-education guidance documents. Check your SEA website directly. These are updated frequently and carry the state-specific policy context your board needs.

Your SEA website → search "artificial intelligence"

CSTA STANDARDS · PROFESSIONAL BODY

CSTA PK–12 CS Standards (2026)

Computer Science Teachers Association standards for PK–12 computer science education, with AI content distributed across the concepts. Increasingly referenced in state curriculum frameworks and accreditation. An essential reference for curriculum planning.

csteachers.org/pk12standards

12 ACCOUNTABILITY

The Superintendent's Annual Accountability Checklist

At the end of each school year, the ACIL completes this checklist and reviews it with the superintendent before the board presentation. Mark items and track percentages over time.

☐ **AI Curriculum Integration Lead: named, active, and compensated**

Y/N, and the compensation amount. If N, this is the first failure point. Everything else depends on it.

☐ **% of faculty who completed Phase 1 PD (target: 40% Year 1, 85% Year 2, 100% Year 3)**

Track by department. If Science is at 90% and Arts is at 20%, that gap is meaningful and needs targeted support.

☐ **% of students who received meaningful AI literacy instruction (target: 25% Y1 → 75% Y2 → 100% Y3)**

Not "exposure to a mention of AI." A lesson, unit, or course where AI was the subject of substantive, purposeful learning.

☐ **AI use policy: published, current (reviewed in the last 12 months), and consistently applied**

Ask three teachers to summarize the policy. If their summaries differ significantly, the policy isn't being consistently applied.

☐ **Employer advisory council: met at least twice, with the counselor and ACIL present and feedback documented**

If the council met once and produced no documented feedback, it was ceremonial. Two substantive meetings with documented curriculum input is the minimum.

☐ **Counselors: completed annual AI labor market training and updated career resources**

Ask a counselor: "What's the automation risk for [a common career your students pursue]?" If they don't know, the training hasn't happened or hasn't landed.

☐ **Number of students who completed an AI-relevant industry credential this year**

Target: 5% Year 1 → 30% Year 2 → 60% Year 3. Track by demographic to identify access gaps.

☐ **AI Readiness Report: published publicly, reviewed by the board, with measurable year-over-year comparison**

If this report doesn't exist, you've created no public accountability for your commitments.

☐ **Obsolete courses dissolved or reformed per the curriculum plan**

Name which courses were dissolved or reformed and what replaced them. If none, name the barrier and when it will be resolved.

☐ **Student AI Ethics Advisory Board: formed, met at least 3 times, produced at least one recommendation reviewed by administration**

If students haven't had formal input into AI policy, you've missed both a learning opportunity and a perspective you genuinely need.

> The students in your high schools right now will enter the workforce before many of these AI tools are even obsolete. They deserve to arrive equipped. This toolkit is only useful if someone acts on it. That someone is you.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Who Wrote This, and What I Don't Know

I am Ryan Lester, a Navy veteran and a first-year MS Foresight student at the University of Houston, in Houston, Texas. I have worked in Navy training roles. From 2008 to 2011 I was an instructor at the Navy schoolhouse in Pensacola, teaching basic avionics troubleshooting to Navy and Marine Corps students. I earned the Navy's Master Training Specialist (MTS) qualification in 2009 by passing three teach-backs, a written exam, and an oral board, and I later sat on MTS oral boards that evaluated other instructors. MTS is the qualification for instructors who mentor, instruct, and evaluate other instructors and develop curricula. At Pensacola I developed and facilitated a four-week leadership course for the Sailors enrolled in the Aviation Electronics school. In my last year that was about 650 Sailors, with a new class starting each week. I was selected as one of four core instructors in the school's MTS academy, which trained and qualified other instructors across a staff of 150. I was also a subject matter expert on F-35 curriculum development, and I facilitated computer-based training.

From 2016 to 2019 I was a drill instructor at Recruit Training Command in Great Lakes, responsible for new Sailors around the clock. Recruits are taught far more than drill. In my role that included management competencies, fitness and health, organizational behavior and development, team building, mental toughness, ethics, problem solving, coaching, conflict management, change management, motivation, communication, military history and operations, and behavioral science. I also coordinated the ship's training team that assessed new Sailors, and ran the Battle Stations 21 capstone event, where I contributed to a Vanderbilt University working group on measuring grit and mental toughness in training. More than 60,000 Sailors went through my own recruit divisions and Battle Stations 21 while I was there. In 2020 I helped train recruits in basic military training at the Fort McCoy detachment, which was stood up during COVID. I am an economist by training and interest, and I am new to teaching civilians.

I am not a school administrator, and I have not run a district or a campus. I built this with AI, checked the research it relies on, and revised it after feedback. I expect parts of it are wrong for your school. I'd rather hear that than have this sit on a shelf. Where it helps, use it. Where it doesn't, tell me.

Free to read, share, and adapt with credit, not for commercial use (CC BY-NC 4.0). Project page: github.com/Lesterhau/ai-education-toolkits · rlperspectives.com

Primary research sources

Research

- Elon University ITDF: "Building a Human Resilience Infrastructure for the AI Age" (2026) and "Being Human in 2035" (2025)
- WEF Future of Jobs Report 2025
- McKinsey Global Institute, "Agents, Robots, and Us" (2025)
- PwC Global AI Jobs Barometer 2025
- MIT AI Risk Initiative
- Stanford Digital Economy Lab, "Canaries in the Coal Mine?"
- Scarfe et al. (2024) · Liang et al. (2023) · Lee et al. (CHI 2025)

Curriculum resources

- AI4K12: ai4k12.org
- MIT Day of AI: dayofai.org
- Generative AI for Educators (Google + MIT RAISE): grow.google/ai-for-educators
- TeachAI: teachai.org
- Code.org AI: code.org/ai

Standards and policy bodies

- CSTA PK–12 CS Standards: csteachers.org/pk12standards
- BLS Occupational Outlook: bls.gov/ooh
- ITDF Center: imaginingthedigitalfuture.org

About this toolkit

This document is free to share, print, and adapt for your district. If you use it with your school board, consider sharing what worked. Share it with every educator you know. The more districts that move, the harder it is for any single district to justify standing still.

> **IMPLEMENTED PART OF THIS IN YOUR DISTRICT?**
>
> Share what worked and what didn't. It goes directly into the next revision. The feedback form is at docs.google.com/forms/d/1DDzUWTZMMfjzm7c4H1B7jWxyzY7pYRQfL7U1_aEflP0/viewform, and responses are credited only with permission.

A companion document is available: The University AI Readiness Toolkit (for presidents and provosts). Built by Ryan Lester · rlperspectives.com · October 2026 · Version 4.1